

Friday, 31 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 25° 18°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 22° 12°	MANCHESTER Light rain 19° 13°	GLASGOW Light rain 16° 11°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

The UK's highest court has given Palestine Action permission to appeal the government's proscription of the group under anti-terrorism legislation.

This means the Supreme Court will review the government's decision to ban the activist group. The ruling could have significant implications for protest rights and the definition of terrorism.

POLITICS · UK
- 2

Tragic news from West Mercia Police, who confirm a five-year-old child has died after being found unresponsive in water.

The child had been reported missing, sparking a search operation. Our thoughts are with the family and everyone affected by this heartbreaking incident.

TRAGEDY · UK
- 3

A suspected leader of the notorious Kinahan gang is facing extradition to the UK on serious charges.

The former boxing promoter has previously been named in court as the head of an international drug cartel. This marks a significant development in the fight against organised crime.

CRIME · UK
- 4

Prime Minister Jenrick is urging Andy Burnham to rule out tax rises to fund social care, as a long-awaited shake-up looms.

The government has not yet ruled out tax increases to pay for the reforms. This debate highlights the ongoing challenge of funding social care in the UK.

POLITICS · UK
- 5

Victims of a disgraced funeral boss are reportedly struggling to get refunds after he defrauded them out of hundreds of thousands of pounds.

Robert Bush scammed 172 people who bought funeral plans, taking over £562,000. It's a truly awful situation for those who thought they were planning for the future.

CRIME · UK

What's coming up

1 **The shortlist for this year's prestigious Mercury Prize has been announced, celebrating the best albums of the year.**

Olivia Dean has received a nomination, while Lily Allen surprisingly missed out. It's always a hotly debated list, showcasing diverse British talent.

ON AIR – Who do you think deserves to win the Mercury Prize this year?

MUSIC · COMING UP

2 **Former England football star Shaun Wright-Phillips is set to swap the pitch for the dancefloor, joining the Strictly Come Dancing line-up!**

The sportsman, son of Arsenal legend Ian Wright, played for clubs including Manchester City. It'll be fascinating to see if his fancy footwork translates to the ballroom.

ON AIR – Do you think Shaun Wright-Phillips has what it takes to win Strictly?

TV · COMING UP

3 **The National Theatre is preparing a special celebration to mark 50 years on London's South Bank this October.**

A free outdoor installation will tell 50 stories from the theatre's half-century. It sounds like a wonderful way to reflect on its rich history and impact.

ON AIR – What's your favourite memory or show from the National Theatre?

THEATRE · COMING UP

4 **Zendaya has opened up about working with Tom Holland on the Spider-Man films, calling him her 'best friend'.**

The couple recently attended the London premiere of their latest film, 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day'. It sounds like their real-life chemistry makes their on-screen dynamic even better.

ON AIR – What's your favourite on-screen couple who are also a couple in real life?

FILM · NOW

5 **Ear plugs are becoming an increasingly popular accessory at music festivals, with many now considering them a must-have.**

They can help protect your hearing and enhance the sound experience. It seems like festival-goers are getting smarter about looking after themselves!

ON AIR – Do you use earplugs at concerts or festivals, or do you prefer to feel the full impact of the music?

MUSIC · NOW

On the schedule

- 1 Newcastle United legend Alan Shearer believes 'challenging times' are ahead for his old club after the departure of manager Eddie Howe.**

The Match of the Day pundit is worried about what will happen next at St James' Park. It's a big moment for the club and its fans.

ON AIR – Do you agree with Alan Shearer that Newcastle are in for a tough period?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 2 There's growing expectation that Newcastle captain Bruno Guimaraes will be joining Arsenal this summer in a deal worth up to £80m.**

This would be a massive transfer if it goes through, potentially strengthening Arsenal's midfield significantly. It's certainly got fans talking!

ON AIR – If Bruno Guimaraes joins Arsenal, do you think it makes them title contenders?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 3 Tottenham's club-record £100m signing Sandro Tonali says it took him '10 minutes' to decide to join Spurs after meeting manager Roberto de Zerbi.**

It seems the new boss made quite an impression on the Italian midfielder. Spurs fans will be hoping he settles in quickly and makes a big impact.

ON AIR – How important is a manager's influence in attracting top players?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 4 Ben Duckett hit an unbeaten half-century as Trent Rockets demolished Welsh Fire in The Hundred, winning by nine wickets.**

Duckett's 52 was helped by the Fire bowling seven no balls in their innings. It was a dominant display from the Rockets.

ON AIR – How much are you enjoying The Hundred this year, and who are you backing?

CRICKET · UK
- 5 Cameron Norrie has booked his place in the Los Cabos Open quarter-finals with a straight-set victory over James Duckworth.**

The British number one is looking strong in Mexico as he continues his run in the tournament. We'll be cheering him on!

ON AIR – Do you think Cameron Norrie has a good chance of winning the Los Cabos Open?

TENNIS · GLOBAL

Quick hits

- 1 The delightful art of 'puddle jumping' is being rediscovered as a simple joy by adults.**
Forget umbrellas, people are finding that a good pair of wellies and a proper splash can be surprisingly uplifting. It's a throwback to childhood fun, proving that some simple pleasures never lose their charm.
- 2 New research suggests that 'colouring in' can significantly reduce stress levels in busy grown-ups.**
It's not just for kids anymore! Taking out a colouring book and some pencils is proving to be a wonderfully mindful way to unwind after a long day, letting your creative side take over.
- 3 The satisfying ritual of 'dusting off old board games' for family nights is seeing a resurgence.**
Instead of screen time, many families are turning back to classic board games for some good old-fashioned fun. It's a brilliant way to connect, laugh, and maybe get a little competitive!
- 4 There's a growing trend for 'micro-adventures' – short, accessible trips close to home.**
People are realising that you don't need to go far to have an adventure; a hike in a local park or a night camping in the garden can provide a real sense of escape and discovery.
- 5 The simple pleasure of 'watching the clouds drift by' is being advocated as a mindful moment.**
Taking a few minutes to gaze at the ever-changing shapes in the sky can be incredibly calming. It's a free and easy way to practise mindfulness and appreciate the natural world around us.
- 6 Home bakers are embracing 'the humble scone' as the ultimate comfort food to perfect.**
From plain to fruit, with jam and cream, the quest for the perfect scone is capturing the hearts (and ovens!) of many. It's a timeless treat that brings a little bit of British tradition into any home.
- 7 The charming habit of 'leaving out food for garden birds' is bringing joy to countless households.**
Filling up bird feeders and watching the feathered visitors is a wonderful way to connect with nature from your own window. It's a small act of kindness that brings a lot of pleasure.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

- Q** Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to decide what to wear in the morning?
- ANSWER:** HOLDING UP TWO DIFFERENT OUTFITS AGAINST THEMSELVES IN THE MIRROR, AS IF THEY'RE HAVING A FASHION BATTLE!

- Q** Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a nice, fresh slice of pizza. What is it?
- ANSWER:** WAVING IT AROUND GENTLY FOR A FEW SECONDS TO 'AERATE' IT, EVEN THOUGH THEY KNOW IT MAKES NO DIFFERENCE!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know those little 'unwritten rules' that you absolutely live by in your daily life, even if nobody else does?**
For example, always putting your right shoe on first, or having a very specific order for loading the dishwasher! What are your quirky, personal unwritten rules?
- **Think about a 'small act of kindness' you've either given or received recently that really brightened your day.**
Perhaps someone let you go ahead in the queue, or you held a door open for a stranger and got a lovely smile. Tell us about the little moments of human connection that made a difference.

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Nature.** Did you know that flamingos are not born pink? They get their distinctive colour from the brine shrimp and algae they eat, which contain a natural pink dye called canthaxanthin.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** It's said that the 'laughing kookaburra' actually gets its name from its habit of 'giggling' when it finds a particularly tasty worm, a sound that can carry for miles across the Australian bush.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£5.9 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£5.9 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's oldest known living tree is a bristlecone pine named Methuselah, estimated to be over 4,800 years old.
- A group of owls is called a parliament.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar on August 27, 1896, lasting only 38 minutes.
- Butterflies taste with their feet.
- The 'richest' soil on Earth is called Chernozem, known for its deep black colour and high fertility.
- The first modern Olympic Games were held in Athens, Greece, in 1896.
- It takes a sloth about two weeks to digest a single meal.
- The average person walks the equivalent of three times around the world in their lifetime.

On this day

Day 212 of the year, 153 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abanoub; Christian feast day: Blessed Cecília Schelingová; Christian feast day: Blessed Solanus Casey; Christian feast day: Fabius. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1974 — Emilia Fox, English actress
- 1969 — Loren Dean, American actor
- 1963 — Norman Cook (Fatboy Slim), English DJ and musician
- 1944 — Geraldine Chaplin, American actress and screenwriter
- 1943 — Lobo, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1940 — Stanley R. Jaffe, American film producer and director (died 2025)
- 1956 — Michael Biehn, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1961 — Frank Gardner, English captain and journalist

THE DAY TODAY

- 1964 — Ranger program: Ranger 7 sends back the first close-up photographs of the moon, with images 1,000 times clearer than anything ever seen from earth-bound telescopes.
- 1988 — Thirty-two people are killed and 1,674 injured when a bridge at the Sultan Abdul Halim ferry terminal collapses in Butterworth, Penang, Malaysia.
- 2012 — Michael Phelps breaks the record set in 1964 by Larisa Latynina for the most medals won at the Olympics.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1975 — The Troubles: Three members of a popular cabaret band and two gunmen are killed during a botched paramilitary attack in Northern Ireland.
- 1948 — USS Nevada is sunk by an aerial torpedo after surviving hits from two atomic bombs (as part of post-war tests) and being used for target practice by three other ships.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2014 — Gas explosions in the southern Taiwanese city of Kaohsiung kill at least 20 people and injure more than 270.
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2008 — East Coast Jets Flight 81 crashes near Owatonna Degner Regional Airport in Owatonna, Minnesota, killing all eight people on board.

- 1938 — Bulgaria signs a non-aggression pact with Greece and other states of Balkan Antanti (Turkey, Romania, Yugoslavia).

A peek at tomorrow

Day 213 of the year, 152 days left in 2026. Today no major UK observance listed. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

THE DAY TOMORROW

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 31 Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7 Once Upon a Time in a Cinema

FRI 14 Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie

FRI 21 Mutiny; The Bride!

FRI 28 Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4 Conjuring: Last Rites

FRI 11 Resident Evil reboot

FRI 18 The Black Phone 2

FRI 25 Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16 Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller

FRI 23 Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026

23 JUL — 2 AUG Commonwealth Games, Glasgow

AUGUST 2026

W/C 10 Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)

SAT 15 Premier League season begins (2026/27)

22–23 Belgian Grand Prix (F1)